

The Pharmacist's Cipher II

Status Report and Partial Retraction

Version 2.0

Alessandro Placa*

Uroboro.io

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What this document is. In March 2026 I published a companion report to "The Pharmacist's Cipher" (DOI: 10.5281/zenodo.19197846) setting out a working morphological model for MS 408, a set of visual-textual convergences, and 39 dated, falsifiable predictions.

Four months of further work have falsified or superseded substantial parts of that report. This document is not a revision of the companion. It is a section-by-section status assessment, to be read *before* the original, which is included unchanged as the second file in this record.

I am retracting the therapeutic-class system, the botanical identifications, the chromatic code, and the cardinal reading of folio f85r. The structural and distributional findings stand, in some cases in reformulated terms. The prediction register stands as a dated record, and one of its entries has since been executed with results that could not have been obtained without it.

Nothing here was prompted by external criticism. The falsifications are my own, produced by the tests the original report asked for.

1 Why this document exists rather than a revised edition

The companion report was explicitly built as an atlas of disciplined hypotheses, with an epistemic label on every section and a declared falsification criterion for each claim. That design has now done its work: enough of those criteria have been met that editing the text in place would produce a document whose surviving claims could no longer be distinguished from its retracted ones.

A reader arriving at the original today cannot tell which of its 29 pages are still load-bearing. That is the problem this status report solves, and it solves it by leaving the original intact and supplying the key to it, rather than by silently rewriting history. The original remains citable at its own DOI, and any claim of intellectual priority I make rests on its March 2026 date, not on a later edit.

2 Section-by-section status

Five verdicts are used. **RETAINED**: the finding stands as stated. **REFORMULATED**: the measurement stands but the interpretation attached to it has been replaced. **RETRACTED**: withdrawn,

*Corresponding author: alessandro.placa@uroboro.io

do not use. DORMANT: registered but never tested, and with no current supporting evidence, so it should be read as an open conjecture rather than a result. EXECUTED: a declared research requirement that has since been carried out.

Section	Status	Assessment
2.1.1 Prefix families and distributional profiles	REFORMULATED	The distributional facts hold, including the anomalous <i>o</i> -prefix rate for <i>s</i> - (4.5% against 54–71%). The framing as “four solvent-prefix families” is now a reading, not a fact: the substance glosses are held at structural-solid / open-reading status. The <i>s</i> - anomaly is better accounted for by the finding that <i>s</i> and <i>d</i> - do not host the gallows morpheme at all.
2.1.2 Segmentation claims	REFORMULATED	Mixed. The decomposition $dy = d + y$ holds. The unitary status of <i>ch</i> and <i>sh</i> holds and has been strengthened: <i>ckh</i> , <i>cth</i> , <i>cph</i> , <i>cfh</i> are now treated as atomic. The coalescence rules $qo + ok \rightarrow qok$ hold and <i>qo</i> has been independently validated across 5,181 occurrences. The falsification of the calligraphic model for simple versus ornate gallows holds, but its replacement has changed (see 2.1.3). The reading of <i>-am</i> as a maceration operator is withdrawn: <i>-am</i> marks completion of a step.
2.1.3 Thermal asymmetry across gallows classes	REFORMULATED	The differential co-occurrence of <i>ch</i> and <i>sh</i> with <i>k/t</i> versus <i>f/p</i> is a real measurement and was an early detection of a genuine split. The reading was wrong. The axis is not thermal but a two-by-two factorization of process domain (wet versus dry), crossed with three graphic grades carried in the feet of the glyph. A further asymmetry has since been measured on the same split: <i>k</i> and <i>t</i> behave lexically, <i>p</i> and <i>f</i> behave positionally.
2.1.4 Distributional complementarity: ornate <i>c_h</i> and bench characters	RETAINED	The complementarity table stands, and the paradigmatic correspondence between ornate forms and simple <i>ch/sh</i> forms was the first evidence for what is now the atomic treatment of the ornate bench characters. The specific interpretation as compression of a <i>thermal</i> marker falls with 2.1.3; the compression finding itself does not.

Section	Status	Assessment
2.1.5 The 224/224 coverage result	REFORMULATED	Superseded by stronger measures rather than falsified. Coverage of first tokens was always offered as compatibility evidence, and it is a weak instrument: a sufficiently flexible agglutinative template will cover almost anything. It has been replaced by direct measurements of the shared skeleton, of the closed prefix inventory, and of the one-gallows-per-word constraint at 97.7%.
2.2.1 Solvent-prefix glosses	REFORMULATED	Demoted from working glosses to open readings. Only <i>l</i> as spirit or alcohol retains independent support. The others are compatible with the distributional evidence but are not entailed by it, and at least three non-pharmaceutical frames survive the same evidence.
2.2.2 Therapeutic class glosses (P-CALM, K-EXCIT, T-PROT, F-ABORT)	RETRACTED	Withdrawn in full. The four gallows identities do not encode therapeutic classes. They encode process domains in a two-by-two-by-three system, and the third dimension of that system is not visible in the transcription alphabet at all. Every claim in this report that uses the four class labels as a column falls with them.
2.2.3 Morpheme glosses	REFORMULATED	Mixed, item by item. Retained and strengthened: <i>o</i> as a locative morpheme, <i>d</i> as a contextual referent, <i>l</i> as spirit, <i>-y</i> as an action marker. Withdrawn: <i>a</i> as a surface preposition (it marks extraction), <i>pol</i> as laudanum, <i>-am</i> as maceration. Reformulated: the <i>e/ee/eee</i> series is a count of processing cycles rather than a quantity gradient, and those cycles have since been shown to attach to the concentrated grade, which kills the reading of cycles as distillation. Dormant: <i>r</i> as a purity marker, the <i>eo</i> system, <i>rain</i> .
2.3 Two orthogonal pairs: <i>sh/ch</i> and <i>s/l</i>	REFORMULATED	The claim that the system carries two independent axes survives and has been generalized. The specific assignment of those axes (thermal versus solvent) does not, and <i>s</i> has since been shown to behave unlike the other three members.
2.4 The verbal paradigms <i>qok-</i> , <i>qot-</i> , <i>qol-</i>	RETAINED	Stands, and is now better supported than when written.
3.1 f86v4 structural anomaly	RETAINED	The structural facts (token density, hapax ratio, bipartite layout, line-1 uniqueness) are correct and remain interesting.

Section	Status	Assessment
3.2 f86v4 operational reading (North, East, South, West cycle)	RETRACTED	Withdrawn. The folio is better described as a hybrid of code and data with a metadocumentary function; its rings contain no tokens of the family the cardinal reading requires. No sequential production cycle is sustainable on current evidence.
3.3 Exploratory interpretations and implied social context	DORMANT	Registered in March as explicitly speculative and never tested since. The mnemonic-song reading and the inferences drawn from it should be treated as conjecture with no supporting work behind them. No biographical or identitarian claim was made then and none is made now.
4 The chromatic code	RETRACTED	Withdrawn. It depends on the botanical identifications retracted below, it was never replicated under a pre-registered protocol, and the direction of inference it relies on cannot be audited after the fact.
5.1 The 3x3 rosette grid: cardinal solvent domains	RETRACTED	Withdrawn, and this one is a genuine falsification rather than a withdrawal for weakness. The report assigned the west rosettes to the acetous domain while noting that no textual confirmation existed. The west band has since been measured, on two independent transcribers with a pre-declared direction, and it belongs to a different family entirely (Fisher odds ratio 4.78, $p = 0.0004$). The east-west axis runs between two families, neither of which is the one predicted.
5.2 Angular rosettes as administration ports	RETRACTED	Withdrawn. The measured organization of the board assigns different roles to those positions.
5.3 Dosage bundles (<i>fasci</i>)	DORMANT	Never tested. The retrovalidation offered in support was a single correlation on a small partition and should not be relied on.
5.4 Implicit base vectors	RETRACTED	Withdrawn: it is stated in terms of the therapeutic classes retracted at 2.2.2.
6.1 The sealed-envelope protocol	DORMANT	The protocol was designed and applied by its author and is therefore not a blind test, as the report itself stated. It produced no result that survived. It is left on record as a method proposal, not as a validated instrument.

Section	Status	Assessment
6.2–6.4 Botanical identifications (17 plants)	RETRACTED	Withdrawn in full, including the high-convergence table, the Solanaceae quartet, and the lower-confidence list. The identifications inherit the retracted therapeutic classes as their organizing column and the retracted chromatic code as their confirmation channel. No plant identification from this report should be cited.
6.5 The Bax retrodiction test	RETRACTED	Withdrawn. It scores predictions that are themselves retracted, against a rubric written by the author, on a sample of eight. The report already flagged these limits; they are now decisive.
11 The falsification register (26 hypotheses)	RETAINED	Stands, and is extended by this document.
12 Epistemological framework	RETAINED	Stands. The self-assessment it contains, 95 out of 100 for internal coherence against 63 out of 100 for external probative force, was accurate, and the events recorded here are what that gap looks like when it is honoured.
14 Cautious notes on the implied producer	DORMANT	Untested inference. Should not be cited.

3 Status of the 39 registered predictions

The prediction register is the part of the companion report that was designed to age, and it has aged as intended: each entry carried a falsification criterion, and the criteria did their work.

Status	Count	Entries
RETAINED	7	P3, P4, P5, P7, P10, P12, P13
REFORMULATED	5	P1, P2, P6, P9, P30
RETRACTED	13	P8, P11, P14, P15, P16, P18, P19, P20, P21, P29, P31, P32, P33
DORMANT	12	P17, P22, P24, P25, P26, P27, P28, P34, P35, P36, P37, P39
EXECUTED	2	P23 (in part), P38
Total	39	

P38, and why the register was worth keeping

Prediction P38 was not a claim about the manuscript. It was a statement about what the research lacked. It said that a paleographic catalogue of the gallows variants, encoding each as a directed stroke sequence, was a necessary precondition for testing the framework, and that it did not exist.

That catalogue now exists. Twelve canonical variants were identified, anchored in the feet of the glyph, and 6,143 gallows have been traced at ductus resolution across the manuscript with a public, versioned dataset behind them.

What it produced was not a confirmation of the March framework. It was a finding the March framework could not have reached and did not anticipate: the variant grade behaves as a third information channel, carried at the level of the individual occurrence, largely independent of the word it sits in and not predictable from its context. A substantial share of the information in the gallows slot is therefore invisible to any transcription alphabet that collapses the variants, including the one this report used throughout.

This is the reason the companion report should not be retracted in full. Its interpretive layer was wrong in the places listed above. Its methodological layer identified, in March, the specific instrument whose absence was blocking progress, and building that instrument is what produced the result that now supersedes much of the report.

4 What this does not change

- **Priority.** The predictions in the original report are dated March 2026 and remain so. Retraction of some of them does not alter the date of the others.
- **Paper I.** The six statistical tests are a separate document and are assessed separately. Four of them stand as measurements. One stands with a rewritten interpretation. One, the morpheme-frequency volume hierarchy, is being withdrawn: it depends on a fifth family that the current model does not recognize as belonging to the same series, and without it the rank correlation does not survive. A corrected edition is in preparation.
- **The open problem.** MS 408 is not deciphered, and nothing in the original report or in this one claims otherwise.

5 Where the work goes

A third paper is in preparation, deliberately agnostic about interpretation. It treats only the sign system and the mathematics of the corpus: the twelve ductus variants and their factorization, the non-random signal they carry, the complete positioned transliteration of the Nine-Rosettes foldout, and the information architecture of the text measured against a genre-matched and size-matched real-language control. It will make no pharmaceutical claim of any kind. It is scheduled to follow the completion of the full positioned transcription rather than to precede it, because the transcription is not supporting documentation for that paper: it is the instrument that makes the third information channel measurable at all.

Readers who want to check the present work rather than the retracted work should wait for that paper, or consult the public datasets in the meantime.

Files in this record

1. This status report (v2.0).
2. `pharmacists-cipher-II_v1.2_superseded.pdf`: the original companion report of March 2026, unaltered, preserved for citation and for the record. Read it through the table in Section 2.

Acknowledgments

Computational analysis was performed with the assistance of Claude (Anthropic). All interpretive decisions, and all errors including the ones retracted here, are the author's responsibility.